

HOUSE No. 4699

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES, November 6, 2025.

The committee on Housing, to whom was referred the petition (accompanied by bill, House, No. 1542) of Meghan K. Kilcoyne and others for legislation to establish a special commission to study and define conditions under which single-stair multi-family residential buildings up to six stories shall be legalized, reports recommending that the accompanying bill (House, No. 4699) ought to pass [Representative DeCoste of Norwell dissents].

For the committee,

RICHARD M. HAGGERTY.

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In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act to study single-stair residential buildings.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 SECTION 1: Notwithstanding any general or special law to the contrary, there shall be a
2 special commission to study and define conditions under which Single-Stair Multi-Family
3 Residential buildings up to six stories shall be legalized in Massachusetts. The commission shall
4 produce a building code amendment that allows single-stair multi-family residential buildings of
5 up to six stories, including measures for mitigating any adverse health and safety impacts unique
6 to single-stair multi-family residential buildings. Said measures mitigating any adverse health
7 and safety impacts would include general fire prevention measures, including smoke alarms,
8 sprinkler systems, fire-resistant materials, emergency exit strategies, and any safety measures
9 pertinent to 527 CMR 1.00.

10 (b) The commission shall consist of the secretary of housing and livable communities, or
11 their designee, who shall serve as chair, 2 members of the Massachusetts House of
12 Representatives, or their designees, 2 members of Massachusetts Senate, or their designees, 1
13 member representing the Fire Chiefs Association of Massachusetts, 2 members of the American
14 Institute of Architects, 1 member who is a practicing fire engineer representing the National Fire

15 Protection Association, 2 members representing the Board of Building Regulations and
16 Standards, 1 member representing the American Planning Association Massachusetts Chapter, 1
17 member representing the Home Builders and Remodelers Association, 1 member representing
18 NAIOP, 1 member representing the Center for Building in North America, 1 member
19 representing a building official employed by a municipality with a Class 1 Fire Department, and
20 1 member representing Abundant Housing Massachusetts.

21 (c) The study shall build on the report Legalizing Mid-Rise Single-Stair Housing in
22 Massachusetts produced by the Harvard Joint Center for Housing Studies, Boston Indicators, and
23 Utile, and shall include, but not be limited to: a technical study into the safety of single-stair
24 residential buildings compared to two-staircase buildings, and a process map and timeline for
25 implementation of drafted building code amendment.

26 (d) Not later than July 31, 2026, the commission shall file its study with the clerks of the
27 house of representatives and the senate and the joint committee on housing.